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Diaspora & Hybridity

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Hybridity and Openness (or, Whose Side are You on?)

The Nation

Business as usual, or chaos? In a so-called post-national world, as we have seen, organized and obedient allegiance to the nation, or to any fixed identity, could perhaps become more difficult. Many are tempted to agree with proclamations of the end of grand narrative and the dissolution of all certitude. The nation, however, is resilient in many spheres – there can be few doubts about the military capabilities of the armed state, and the framework of governance and national boundary maintenance still takes quite orthodox forms. It might be a good test of the extent to which diaspora and hybridization have or have not undermined totalizing thought to ask what hybrid or diasporized forms of governance or border control might look like? Examples could be assembled, imagined, projected, but just who claims hybridity, and why, should be our questions when we again approach writing on the twin juggernauts of identity and the nation-state.

Everyone seems to accept that questions of the nation, and assertions of national identity, seem fraught today in the face of globalization-inspired uncertainty. The idea of the national is threatened by the consequences of a serious consideration of diaspora and hybridity. In its mainstream forms, it is 'place of birth' and nationalism – allegiance to the homeland – that are at stake when hybridity (or diaspora) is valorized as the postmodern or post-colonial condition. The idea of some primordial grounding in place is questionable as soon as it becomes a criterion for denial and exclusion of others. The idea of hybrid identity in diaspora as an anchor has its advocates. Paul Gilroy once suggested diaspora as an alternative to 'the stern discipline of kinship and rooted belonging' (Gilroy 2000: 123) – it delinks location and identity and it disrupts bounded notions of culture and racialized bodily attribution. The possibility of rethinking the contingency of commemoration and shared memory is not the only benefit here. Hybridity can become both a positive eventuality for some, and a constructed anchoring device for others (nautical metaphor intended).

Yet while hybridity is not proffered as the answer in every instance, its valorization proceeds apace in avowedly political circles. Kobena Mercer was among those to suggest that 'emerging cultures of hybridity' might offer something of importance. Although including some caveats, his context is an urgent Black politics that will

challenge the bounded national polity of Britain, and he writes, quoting Gramsci:

It would be preposterous to claim that Black British culture offers a 'solution' to the crisis of authority that will take us into the twenty-first century, but nevertheless I suggest that the emerging culture of hybridity, forged among the overlapping African, Asian and Caribbean diasporas, that constitute our common home, must be seen as crucial and vital efforts to answer the 'possibility and necessity of creating a new culture' so that you can live. (Mercer 1994: 3–4)

New cultural hybridity becomes the panacea for uncertain times, and in conditions of diasporic hybridization, without the certainty of the nation-state or class-identity for comfort, we may usefully and chaotically affirm promiscuity at every turn. In this conception, hybridity is a contender for a 'new model' of social possibility that will assert 'uncertainty' as its political guide.

Home

The polarization implied in the terminology of hybridity (a mix of cultures; of here and there) is most dubious when generalized in the diasporic context under the sanctity of the 'home' (or home culture; think 'home countries' or 'homeland security' here).¹ As we will see, the dynamic of hybridity as process is beset by several problems, even in its most progressive forms. The first and foremost of these, as detailed in the previous chapter, is the tendency to reaffirm, even in process, ideas of fixed and prior 'cultures' which enter into the exchange of hybridity – the hybrid is either compromised already or left twisting in emergent suspension between two more coherent wholes. It is here that the problematic of so-called postmodernity can be rethought as the malaise of muddled hybridity thinking – the mix of old and new, of different styles, the pastiche of elements that reaffirms the old. The question of novelty emerges, often in discussion of post-colonial identities, as the character of self in the contemporary globalized metropolis, yet the post-colonial always remains new, an arrivee from 'over there'.

Here and there, the host and the visitor; as with all ascribed positions, these entail degrees of implied uniformity that oftentimes congeal into hardened categories. The very idea of a 'host' and an 'arrivee' culture assumes a degree of non-hybridity which is difficult to sustain unless there is an insistence on an unbridgeable difference between the here and the there. The co-constitution of locations under global imperialism is denied, in effect, with calculated intent. The idea of the host is a property claim, a claim to ownership, home-

land, right, authority. The idea of the host as 'not hybrid' resident of a homeland takes its most spurious forms in white supremacy and nationalist chauvinism. This is paralleled, with less violent consequences no doubt, in ideas of musical ownership, where proprietary rights to sounds are claimed and types of music are ascribed to national and cultural groups, as in Indian music, Chinese music, African-Caribbean music etc. As we will see in [Chapter 6](#), the absent designation here is 'whiteness' – never ascribed, thus granting assumed centrality and coherence.

Against cultural ascription, critics of essentialism point out that simply investigating the diasporic, historically mixed, culturally diverse origins of even the most 'Aryan' assertions of origin and purity will reveal hybridity in all cases – the Anglo-Saxon is as much the hyphen as Hindus are the peoples on the other side of the Indus river (we have already seen that there are problems with the claim that everyone is already hybrid, already diasporic).² In *Dis-Orienting Rhythms*, Raminder Kaur and Virinder Kalra used the hyphenated and inventively ironic term 'Br-Asian' to point out the 'hybridity inherent in all identifications' (Kaur and Kalra 1996: 230). Papastergiadis wants to affirm the power of the hyphen in hybridity, 'the energy that comes from conjunction and juxtaposition' (Papastergiadis 2000: 143). In [Chapter 2](#), we noted how certain hyphenated identities can reinforce national identification, such as British-Indian, but that diasporic spaces also evoke new hyphenated formations, such as Asian-Muslim. In such cases, the terms either side of the hyphen are not the constituent parts, but rather what might be called a co-constituting – and often unstable, in-translation, interactive – entity. Bhabha writes that 'hybrid hyphenations emphasize the incommensurable elements – the stubborn chunks – as the basis of cultural identifications' (Bhabha 1994: 219).

Reworking hybridity in this way would entail neither a triumphant synthesis nor a partial or unfinished negativity, unless it insisted on the certainty, or fixity, of the constituted whole. Anti-essentialist scholarship has continually attempted to critique this with a comprehension seeking to leave differences as different, but to recognize them as somehow always erupting, in order to move elsewhere once again, renewed. The test is to decide whether the moribund stasis of the essential, of the nation, of the Aryan in the hands of the totalitarian group, and so on, is the antithesis of this effervescent hybridity, or if hybrid identity falls prey to its own illogic by merely asserting a new same.

In the racialized landscape of urban Britain, synonyms of hybridity appear to provide for a description of geography that disguises deep-seated, entrenched inequalities. Diversity is the codeword that foregrounds the marketable aspects of neglected and run-down inner-urban areas while maintaining a hegemonic base for capital and the conventions of the old and established. This is demonstrated in the compulsive reporting of

housing price inflation in the UK and the search for brown-field areas for investors. In both newspaper supplement glossy specials on prime neighborhoods and in governmental schemes for renovation and renewal, there is a denial of lived experience of differences. The needs of residents conflict with real estate profiteering where the ever-present population is excluded by means of government planning which takes form of policies for taxing the poor (the problem of class hierarchy), by reporting that is focused upon destitute asylum-seekers (problems of racial profiling) and by general neglect of those for whom the rhetoric of diversity has little meaning (the homeless, disenfranchised, unemployed). Cultural diversity stands or falls upon the stability of real estate values and suburban reputations, and while 'some' local colour is favoured, the most 'mixed' areas do not feature high on the scales of services or interest. At this juncture the rhetoric of government housing schemes as 'opportunities for all' rests upon a refusal to address already existing material hierarchy. The new opportunities are distributed 'fairly', the contracting spread across all zones. With the winding back of the welfare state, hybridity and pluralism achieve a devious sleight-of-hand, presenting the banality of equal and fair treatment as egalitarianism without reserve – with privileges for just a few. If this were not so brutal, it would be comic. We are all the same in our differences: single mothers, refugees, Anglo-Saxons and Poles. The premature insistence on equality for all ensures the permanent retention of privilege for some.³

So the trouble with hybridity is that it does not offer an adequate language to discuss even the mundane exchanges of cultural difference in so-called 'postmodernity', let alone come to grips with contemporary social, political and economic conditions. This is not simply to say that things are more complex, although there are reasons to entertain this notion. Nicholas Thomas offers a Pacific example when he suggests that cultural artefacts found in the context of 'colonial contact' are not always 'productively seen as hybrid objects or expressions of hybrid identity'. They may be culturally mixed – he has in mind contemporary Pacific Island art forms – but the:

culturally 'mixed' nature of these objects does not somehow reflect or express a mixed 'identity' because it reflects no identity. If we describe these artefacts as bearers of a hybrid identity, we may be imprisoning them in a frame that is no less misleading and invidious than that of colonial ethnic typification. (Thomas 2000: 199)

A similar lack of adequacy is identified by Lola Young, who makes the useful point that Black is not about melanin content, it 'may be thought of as always already "hybrid" and any attempt to use it as a homogeneous, self-contained category is contingent on a political interpretation' (Young 2000: 166). Against the cultural essentialisms of interest groups, a political alliance under the term 'Black' as an anti-racist category re-

mains viable for some.⁴ Such Black alliance does not explicitly feature in the trajectory Young follows, but her dismissal of melanin grading is of course welcome. For others, hybridity is of little use to a Black politics. Salman Sayyid offers the point that 'at the same time as making possible the weakening of hegemonic formation, cultural hybridity makes it impossible to displace the hegemonic formation' (Sayyid 2000a: 267). This is because, as Sayyid has it, subaltern cultural formations are unsustainable in the face of a critique of absolutism or essentialism, and strategic essentialism is a reactive and thereby restricted response. The adoption of essentialism in circumstances which excuse an indentitarian mobilization may appear to work in some circumstances, but it often proceeds in unexamined ways and with dubious consequences we want to keep in mind.⁵ Throughout this book we have presented an uneasy oscillation between the progressive possibilities (as expressed by Mercer) and the limitations of terms such as 'hybridity' and 'diaspora'. The positions of Young and Sayyid again evoke the differing viewpoints. But, we would also suggest that hybridity as politics seldom addresses how capitalism forces an equivalence in which all differences can be made similar by the market; various and fragmented yes, but always up for sale.

Racial Absolutism

The discursive replication of hybridity-talk deserves the critical attention it receives, if only to make explicit what is not being said. Gilroy calls for us to find 'an adequate language for comprehending mixture outside of jeopardy and catastrophe' (Gilroy 2000: 217). More than descriptive capacity is needed. Gilroy is correct, but for slightly skewed reasons when he declares his hand:

We do not have to be content with the halfway house provided by the idea of plural cultures. A theory of relational cultures and of culture as relation represents a more worthwhile resting place. That possibility is currently blocked by banal invocations of hybridity in which everything becomes equally and continuously intermixed' (Gilroy 2000: 275)

As the culture industry makes all differences equivalent, the dilemma is that any 'resting place' is a kind of complicity internal to the problem – capitalist encroachment upon all aspects and varieties of life – mixed or stable, it does not matter which. Like descriptive and theoretical competency, 'resting' means nothing if unable to examine and work past complicity in its own subsumption and suppression. The plurality of cultures, or the truism that everything is hybrid, surely leads to the torturous reasoning of 'if so, so what?' – that is, stasis.

Maybe it is the mongrel, interfering, mix that undermines racialist absolutism, and it is the corrosive friction of intercourse and exchange that destabilizes purity and property by right. But is it also perhaps the message of hybridity that reassigns fixed identity into what becomes merely the jamboree of pluralism and multiplicity? So what then for adequacy and the necessary struggle? Paul Gilroy's risky venture of arguing his way 'beyond' race can be followed in a trajectory that also moves to a kind of beyond of hybridity. He wants a 'new idiom' for discussion of the transcultural in a way that can comprehend mixture in ways that are not stuck in 'jeopardy and catastrophe':

Finding this valuable new idiom does not require merely inverting the polarity of hybridity's internal circuits so that what was previously seen as loss, dilution, and weakness becomes valuable instead and offers an opportunity to celebrate the vigorous cosmopolitanism endowed in modernity by transgressive and creative contacts with different people. ... Perhaps ... we might begin to comprehend ... 'transcultural mixture', and the assumptions about alterity that it promotes, as phenomena without any necessary or fixed value at all. (Gilroy 2000: 217)

The aim is to push through to a position where 'viable notions of civic reciprocity' make obsolete any registration of 'the forms of otherness signified by that narrow band of phenotypical variations that produces racialized difference' (Gilroy 2000: 217). The problem, of course, with these 'modest aspirations' that would allow (constructed, projected, essentialized) racial difference to pale into insignificance is that [civic] 'reciprocity' – or gift exchange – is well known in anthropology and philosophy as a kind of trick or gamble, bound up indeed with an economy of debt and obligation, as well as theft and extortion. Jacques Derrida has discussed this in terms of Immanuel Kant and the impossibility of legislating for hospitality (you cannot be forced to offer a 'welcome') and again like translation, the extreme of purity is shown not to exist (Derrida 2001). This is the key to explaining the refusal of the Australian government to welcome migrants (despite a tri-century history of 99 per cent migration) and to characterize those in detention camps as uninvited queue-jumpers (MacCullum 2002). Hospitality is political; there are no altruistic gifts and the ideal world of exact reciprocity cannot be conjured into place without massive redress of already established disequilibria (Bataille 1988; Derrida 1992). The drive to define and fix definitions is just what makes useless the categories of so much social science: caught in stasis, the closed character of analysis can only replicate itself, unable to attend to dynamic and contradictory processes in capitalism and social life as lived.

Allegiance to fixed categories, or their uncategorical rejection, is a deranged form of (not) thinking that settles on concepts or fetishizes them as objects (for or against) rather than using them to open up analysis and

understandings to be challenged. However attractive the idea, however fragile the concept, it is not yet time to disregard (the effects of) 'race' as a criteria for assessing the extent of redress and reparation for crimes committed on the basis of racism. Similarly, hybridity provokes discussion and thought, clarification of ideas and action. Thus, the withering away of the category of race is also an ideal, part and parcel of a dictatorship of all oppressed peoples, united in losing their chains, different in ways that can ultimately be disregarded in economic terms. But while shared oppression mobilizes those fighting against racist attack, the terminology of racism cannot be wholly abandoned just yet – not everyone has achieved the middle-class credentials to evade the ghettos. Even those 'cultural activists' who explicitly claim a left political orientation around a hybridity of alliances against racism are no less exempt. This is summed up neatly by Lauren Berlant and Michael Warner when they write that 'a rhetoric of alliances and hybridity can work to proliferate and coordinate different forms of identity politics, but a formalism of hybridity does not necessarily break with a consumerist relation to identity' (Berlant and Warner 1994: 112). In an important essay in *Dis-Orienting Rhythms*, Ashwani Sharma has made the point that the concept of hybridity can be incorporated into 'cultural politics' in a way that sees it 'reworked by hegemonic structures to produce new marginalized and essentialized identities, keeping in place and perpetuating the violence of "postmodern" culture' (A. Sharma 1996: 20).

Hybridity Going Native

Where might we find the thinking that could transmute interest in hybridity into an analysis that works? We do not want to dismiss out of hand the cultural abundance that hybridity theory seems to promise. But against celebratory-critical accounts, our contention is that interminable discussion of hybridity will usually just facilitate continued culture industry feasting upon plurality and difference. Michael Wayne criticizes 'postmodernism' for advocating 'a liberal multiculturalism or hybridity at the expense of understanding the material divisions that can exist irrespective of cultural exchanges' (Wayne 2002: 212). Rather than a politics of hybridity, what we see is a diminished hybrid market place of trinkets and emblems, sometimes writ large to avoid issues of racial and economic justice. Substantial struggles are subsumed as the cannibalizing capacity of capital is served up for all to see. Expression, creative exchange, and the possibility of political struggle are left to putrefy in the rest-stop of smorgasbord culture.

The examples can be multiplied by a consideration of what is and what is not considered hybrid, and why. We can examine explicit public moments of cultural exchange – food, music, film – and ask if hybridity helps

our analysis of the culture industry. There are many culinary instances. For example, hybridity can be reduced to the curiosities of the 'curry house' where the national dish of England, 'Chicken Tikka Masala', can be consumed. This described in inimitable style by Koushik Banerjea and Jatinder Barn: wherein a 'peculiar hybrid performance' has the boozed-up white punters of Britain temporarily relinquishing 'the mantle of purity' – irony here – for the consumption of a 'gastronomically challenging Other' (Banerjea and Barn 1996: 216; Kalra 2004). There is, of course, also the equally tasty goreng mix that Chua Beng-Huat puts on the table: the *mee-goreng*, served in Singapore is known as 'Indian food' although it is made of noodles (*mee*), which are Chinese and not an Indian staple, and *goreng*, which is Malay for frying. It is served by Indian hawkers and not found in the 'imagined homeland of Singaporean Indians' (Chua 1998: 187). Chua also noted that there are Halal forms of Chinese food, and many other examples can be listed on the postcolonial menu. Food is not the only banality subjected to hybrid categorization. Conversely, there are a number of examples that are ostensibly just as equally mixed but, to date, have not been designated as hybridity: for example, backpackers, television, Maoism in Asia, Jimi Hendrix.⁶ But Hendrix described merely as 'hybrid' would not capture the mischief of what Michael Franti called his 'fucking up of the star-spangled banner' (Spearhead concert, Manchester 1997) at Woodstock in 1969. The sonorously climactic, still problematically commercialized, rendition of that tune offered a fitting soundtrack to the defeat of the USA in its war on Vietnam. It prompts us to ask just why some things are foregrounded as hybrid and some not?

What matters perhaps is to ask questions about the motives behind ascriptions of mixture or hybridity in popular culture. It often seems that the mixed character of cultural product is selectively applied. British Asian women idealizing a Manchester United footballer in the film *Bend it Like Beckham* (dir. Gurinda Chadha 2002) is readily remarked, in reviews, using terms such as 'culture-clash', 'traditions versus cultural homogeneity', and even 'hybridity at play'.⁷ The film earns awards and box-office dollars. Whereas the player in question, David Beckham's misspelled Hindi tattoo running up his left arm, his wife's band's name, his first and second sons' names or his move to Real Madrid are not deemed by necessity to be described as hybrid.

Keeping to the world of film, Richard 'Cheech' Marin, starring in *Born in East L.A.* (dir. Richard Marin 1987) is described as hybrid, to the exclusion of the film's insightful political critique. Addressing the issue of immigration restrictions at the US-Mexican border, Marin's 'third Generation' Chicano character is deported to Mexico even though he doesn't speak a word of Spanish (see Noriega 2001: 190). In this context, the Mariachi version of Hendrix's 'Purple Haze' in the film is also not simply 'fusion'. Nor the fact that in the film 'Indian' and 'Chinese' would-be border-crossers are played by Latinos in wigs and makeup. Marin's character teaches

these stand-ins how to pass as Chicano to avoid deportation once inside the USA, knowingly invoking the Chinese Exclusion Act that was in operation from 1882 to 1943 (Noriega 2001: 197).

Would it be to go too far to think mischievously with this discussion of 'passing for a local' that hybridity might mean an openness to diversity such that we would have to redeem the old anthropological transgression of 'going native' for new times? Picking up on the idea of the translator as an impossible poet, and the trinket collector as the archivist of the global, might there somehow be an ideological reversal and restructuring to enable a context open to this as an entertaining idea? The intellectual commissars of culture remain hostile to many forms of what might readily be called hybrid if found in the 'margins' rather than as staples of dominant white privilege. Hendrix, Marin and Derrida might all enact a politics of the in-between. Yet the project of cultural diversity was first of all claimed by the elite classes, those children of the upper classes sent to view the art and culture of Europe, now transmuted into Peace Corps and NGO volunteerism by the charity-set bent on bringing democracy and decency to the downtrodden. 'Going native' persists in taking the most mundane forms, especially where gap-year university students return from their travels adorned with the flotsam and jetsam of the souvenir markets of the world. Why is this not also called hybridity? Other border-crossers from the white side are even less qualified and become traitors to the national: the soldier in Terrance Mallick's 1998 film *The Thin Red Line* goes absent-without-leave (AWOL) and lives among the indigenous people of the Solomon Islands; the beatnik, wigga, hippy and feral transgress against national belonging and the cornucopia of decency; the revolutionary communist, as much as the mystic or schizophrenic, departs from approved bourgeois identity and from the national(ist) ideal. These figures are not named as hybrids so much as loss, rebellion, deviance – the old moves of integration prevail.⁸ There is good reason to consider the selective ascription of hybridity to the marginal, and not the centre, and to examine this at the crucial juncture of identity in a way that evaluates openness to difference: to what degree does the hybrid interrupt dominant identifications and reveal refusals and blockages of hegemonic nationalist order? Floya Anthias offers a pithy formulation:

It could be argued that the acid test of hybridity lies in the response of culturally dominant groups, not only in terms of incorporating (or co-opting) cultural products of marginal or subordinate groups, but in being open to transforming and abandoning some of their own central cultural symbols and practices of hegemony. (Anthias 2001: 12)

What this leaves us with is, of course, that it is not the mere fact of openness, going native or hybrid that would satisfy the 'acid test', but what sort of hybridity and openness? A celebrated hybridity that enables an

opening for the capitalist market to difference, migration and the exotic does little to challenge 'practices of hegemony'. Just as inserting a hyphen in the representation of the nation can present a sleight of hand to avoid issues of racial justice, 'going native' is possibly just another mode of commercialization of difference; the extension of commodity relations to each and every one of our exchanges.

Border Exchanges

If hybridity selectively seeks out its subjects and these still form around the well-known categories of racialized difference, the exploited and the marginal, it is perhaps relevant to see whether this diversionary process is also at play in some related concepts. In particular, borders are often evoked in discussions of hybridity, but notions of population and its control by borders are not. David Morley, in a magisterial survey-like coverage of cultural studies texts, makes the point that an 'internal hybridity is the necessary correlative to a greater openness to external forms of difference, and is thus the condition of a more porous and less rigidly policed boundary around whatever is defined as the home community' (Morley 2000: 6). The burden of his book, *Home Territories: Media, Mobility and Identity*, is the need to 'move beyond the singularity of perspective that has characterised ... traditional nationalism so as to construct a sense of identity, security and stability which is more open to others, beyond its own narrow confines' (Morley 2000: 260). Could the community, or non-traditional nation, even the diaspora or the hybrid, be a matter of openness? Could such groupings become more open to others unless those others become selves? Here borders are not just opened but abolished, community becomes universal. Are we all going native? mixing? diversifying? Diversity, for others, is a fashion for cosmopolitan intellectuals unconcerned with hybridity except in their narrow localities. Openness to hybridity in the centre has not, for Gayatri Spivak, meant openness to the predicament of those not yet able to access the urban utopias. On the contrary, we can identify, at least anecdotally, a decline of interest in, knowledge about and solidarity with those on the wrong side of the imperialist divide. Spivak's withering critique of postcolonial complacency suggests we should look at how a selective openness works in hybridity talk so as to come to be presented as a political strategy (Spivak 1999). This again raises the question of what a radical openness to alterity would look like. At any rate, is it a coherent possibility, or does coherence and appearance hardly matter in a place – the planet – where difference is the condition of all? Is there a global political project in hybridity or is some other code for redistribution required? We can begin to assess such questions and search out a politics of radical openness if we start with Brah and Coombs' idea that the use of the concept of hybridity has sometimes produced 'an uncritical celebration of the traces of cultural syncretism

which assumes a symbiotic relationship without paying adequate attention to economic, political and social inequalities' (Brah and Coombs 2000: 1).

The discussion of translation and the metaphoric charge of 'border theory', found in terms such as 'transgression', 'crossover' and 'fusion' should not obscure the real and brutal practical politics of borders. However much the appealing formulas of crossover might be emphasized, the material and political impact of sharp blockages to travel – immigration law, customs officers, detention camps, deportations – mean the theory seems to fall somewhat short of the line. E. San Juan Jr. suggests that notions of 'syncretism and interstitiality [as code words for hybridity] might better be read as ciphers for the erasure of the record of "popular democratic" and collective resistance' (San Juan 2002: 14). In particular, he asks how a 'refinement' of 'research into diasporas, immigration, transcultural or border-crossing phenomenon [might] insure us against subordination'. He wonders if 'transcultural' or 'transmigration' studies can produce 'knowledge useful for an oppositional, not to say emancipatory, project' (San Juan 2002: 153).

The politics of crossing borders – and campaigns against the detention camps which maintain borders – in particular seem unjustly served by theoretical arabesques around the hybrid. There is little need for theory that leads to inaction. And it is difficult to see how the mixture and the cross-referenced enthusiasm of some explicitly political border-crossing events are all that usefully described as hybrid. As an example, we might consider what happened in Australia over the Easter weekend in 2002, with the liberation of detainees at the Woomera detention camp. In the remote desert 'outback', activists trespassed the security fences and surrounds of the detention camp, normally well-guarded by the Wakenhut Security Corporation, and 50 detainees awaiting forced 'repatriation' to Afghanistan and Iraq were able to escape through the razor wire fence. Many of these people were recaptured by state police, but a number of them made it to the city centres of Sydney and Melbourne to enjoy café latte and pizza. There was a very tangible sense here that something more than 'hybridity theory' had been put into practice through the diversity and creativity – and militancy – of the action.⁹ But it is significant that, to date, none of the prominent border or hybridity theorists have felt inclined to comment. Indeed, upon watching the video of this event at a conference on migration in Manchester in 2003, well-known urban theorist and self-identified migrant, Saskia Sassen, raised instead questions of the legality of these trespassings. Forsaking 'others' in the desert, the Australian government continues to patrol its borders, internal (detention camps) and external (coastal, airports), to protect itself from the threat of 'alien' refugees. The detention camps in the desert are the obverse side of the hybrid metropolis. If diaspora refers to a moment of forced exile from nation, what do we make of that pain and trauma when it becomes a comfortable cultural(ist) asset that excludes newer arrivals – on the one side some are co-opted, on the

other occluded, excluded and jailed? Those who are blocked from this translation can only wait for 'illegal' support.¹⁰

Similar ways in which the theoretical can be supplemented might readily be found. We would support a mode of activism which works through a kind of neglect of the excesses of hybridity and diaspora talk, but which stresses both internationalism and migrant politics. This is confirmed if we look at how examples of metro-pole-based solidarity movements are organized by diasporic people who do not only focus on the theoretical significance of their condition: 'Che-Leila' in Sussex fighting for Palestinian, Cuban and Iraqi self-determination would be one; the leaflets and posters collected to document the history of the Asian Youth Movements in Britain would be another.¹¹ It is rare to find these movements describing themselves as post-colonial, let alone hybrid, but there is no question that the interests they pursue come out of the same field of struggle that hybridity theorists pertain to address. The problem with theorizing here is that it sometimes clouds the issues, and opportunism born of conceptual sophistication can overwrite the urgency of politics.

Urbanization-Causes-Hybridity?

The excess of border theory provides an apt example of the way that syncretism and hybridity, as academic conceptual tools, provide an alibi for lack of attention to politics. Where Gilroy calls 'syncretism ... that dry anthropological word' (Gilroy 1994: 54) there might be reason to be suspicious of the ways previous scholarly attention has focused on movements of mixture. The old explanatory routine of population pressure and subsequent urbanization as the root of all ills for contemporary society was much discussed in the syncretism literature of anthropology. These themes should feature prominently in critical discussions of hybridity. Where Papastergiadis writes approvingly of the 'teeming hybridity of the postcolonial city' (Papastergiadis 1998: 175), there might be an opportunity for an incursion that remembers all those excluded from that city and trying to get in. Garcia Calclini also offers a typical example:

Undoubtedly urban expansion is one of the causes that intensified cultural hybridization. What does it mean for Latin American cultures that countries that had about 10 percent of their population in cities at the beginning of the century now concentrate 60 to 70 percent in urban agglomerations? (Garcia Calclini 1995: 207)

Surely, the rural population remains part of any demographic, especially where its movement is blocked (see

the essays on the limits to travel theory in Kaur and Hutnyk 1999), and this in turn raises questions about who can and who cannot be considered hybrid or open to hybridity. Scare stories about over-population in the Third World, with subsequent campaigns for fertility control and the tightening of immigration restrictions, intractable asylum law and reduction of refugee programmes, should all be questioned as the nether side of an hierarchical prejudice and exclusion. In his book *Population and Development*, Frank Furedi offers a cogent critique of the way population 'paranoia' and 'the goal of population stabilization' and control 'took precedence over that of development' (Furedi 1997: 73, 80–84). In an equally crucial commentary, Gargi Bhattacharyya, John Gabriel and Stephen Small (2002) foreground 'population scare' as a metonym for a range of anxieties about the degradation of racial privilege. Closures abound.

Many of those who had the good sense, relative fortune, or circumstantial luck to escape agricultural slavery (under feudal lords or under industrialized farming) by means of migration to the rich metropolis find themselves still to be afflicted by an international division of labour remapped across multiple zones. In the cities of the West as much as in the peripheral metropolises, the newly industrialized enclaves and the re-pauperized *barrios*, there continues a comprehensive demarcation. It should be clear that those who escaped the peasant predicament only to exchange landlords for racists and institutional discrimination are probably marginally, materially, better off than their excluded brethren, still caught at the sharp end of IMF and World Bank agricultural policy. Those who remain in the theatre of that peasantry now find the emigration option replaced by sweatshop microproduction, service subservience or street-corner begging (perhaps just a few can avail themselves of new romantic tribal ethnicities so as to attend liberal colloquia on first peoples, but at best it is more likely they will be found hawking trinkets to backpackers). This does not mean they are the problem; equally, they are not to be romanticized. We should certainly salute the attempt of those workers who refuse slavery, and those who struggle under the wire (or risk asphyxiation on a channel tunnel crossing wedged underneath a lorry, or the danger of drowning on a makeshift raft in the Florida Keys), but we cannot pretend that running away is the revolution. On the whole, prospects seem slim for those who want to escape the immiseration of their situations. The issue is not over-population, and to use this as criteria for limiting redistribution is the ideological programme excused by the urbanization-causes-hybridity thesis. What must be analysed as more than a descriptive condition are the turbulent effects of population migration that, glossed as diaspora and settlement, has rearranged the necessities of struggle and life. Whether it be the settler colonialists in Australia, Southern Africa or the Americas, the Chinese in Malaysia and Indonesia, Tamils and Bangladeshis in the Gulf or Punjabis in Britain – and so many more examples – an openness fostered by hybridity does little to undo exploitation and inequality.

The generalized fear of hybridity is also played out in science fiction urbanization scenarios where the cities of the future are imagined as dystopias of ethnic mixture – urbanization leads to the Asian hybrid future of *Bladerunner* (dir. Ridley Scott 1982) in Los Angeles 2019 or the Islam-inflected megalopolis of the twenty-fifth century in *The Fifth Element* (dir. Luc Besson 1997). Like sexual mixture, urban crowding is fantasized as a problem to be worked through by agents of law: as with any number of (white, Western) sci-fi heroes, Decker in *Bladerunner* and Korben Dallas in *The Fifth Element* both fight to preserve the purity of the earth from non-human invasion. The Federation of *Star Trek* police space with patrols to manage threatening, endlessly multiplying, differences. It was German National Socialism that wanted *Lebensraum* – room to live – and tried to expand the borders of Germany. The Japanese imperial government of the 1930s went in for the co-prosperity sphere, which is akin more to economic imperialism than settler colonization. More recently, US imperialism marches to war in Afghanistan and Iraq in the interests of corporate building contracts and resource extraction. All these modes of expansion are figured in the off-world adventures of *Bladerunner*, *The Fifth Element*, *Star Trek* and many other films where planetary expansion involves ‘terra-firming’ and conquest or pacification before acclimatization. The task of adapting Mars to human habitation (*Mission to Mars*, *Red Planet*, dir. Anthony Hoffman 2000; dir. Brian de Palma 2000) is a well-worked variant of the *Lebensraum* ambition and is motivated by the same failures to deal justly with the here and now. By displacing thought about life problems ‘here’ today on to fantasies of the future ‘there’, what do we avoid?

On this planet it is the local ‘aliens’ who are a terminological problem for sociological classification as much as for state administration. Talk of urbanization processes reveals the ways descriptions congeal into a conceptual refusal to recognize settlement, opting instead for models of arrivals, second generations, immigrants, hybrids – as if these categories were ever stable and could be applied to really existing groups of people. As always from elsewhere, the lived-in formation of the centre is made subservient to an assumed but unchallenged, template – as if there were original rightful inhabitants. Londoners, in this example, are not those who live in London, but rather the ‘residue’ of the white ‘east-enders’ whose brethren mostly decamped to the almost suburban Essex in ‘white flight’. The racist cartography of urbanization is clear and can then be mapped on to the class position of advocates of hybridity-talk. Of course then the east-end lads image becomes passé as hybridity is recruited to remake London as the multicultural capital, dining out on its mixed cuisine (expensive venues, underpaid and undocumented service staff) and its multiracial vibe (hints of danger, licentious scenes). It is in the interests of those invested in a certain version of multiculturalism to honour integrated ‘ethnic’ fractions and well-meaning white people alike in the polite society of the suburban milieu, with excellent services and shopping malls galore. In an indulgent inner-urban ghetto-exotica an economically

privileged fantasy cosmopolitanism can risk a dark inner-city evening out. Of course any political assessment that might carve up the surplus in a more equitable way, locally or globally, is left unconsidered.

Just as in the previous chapter we often found anxiety about cross-racial sexuality behind discussions of cultural survival, syncretism, hybridity and mixture, at least historically, in the contemporary period a similar investment provokes concern about urbanization. These 'scourges' of cultural homogeneity are seen to operate alongside a hybridity-talk that is unable and unwilling to defend against exclusionary attacks – the champions of hybridity appear complicit in the middle-class comforts that their own cosmopolitan lives afford, while denying the same to others left to languish in the 'Third World' and rural extraction zones. It is an 'unrestful' conclusion that the tranquil discussions of cultural hybridization, diaspora and mixture do little more than confirm middle-class securities and draw others into the hegemony of a fabricated, and commercialized, diversity. This is, indeed, the 'tranquillizing hybridization' (Garcia Calclini 2000: 48) that the culture industry develops as panacea for putting up with socio-economic disparities. Hybridity lulls us to sleep.

Lessons of Hybridity?

To wake us up: this might, finally, be the place to ask again if the use of a term like 'hybridity', in the social sciences, offers understandings hitherto unavailable, and do these understandings then form any sort of basis for political consciousness and a project of emancipation? Or is it merely the case that hybridity offers up no more than festivals of difference in an equalization of cultures that would confirm Adorno's worst fears of a market that sells 'fictitiously individual nuances' (Adorno 1991: 35) in a standardized world, where each product must claim to be 'irreplaceably unique' (Adorno 1991: 68)? Garcia Calclini is alert to this when he writes:

When hybridization is the mixing of elements from many diverse societies whose peoples are seen as sets of potential consumers of a global product, the process that in music is called equalization tends to be applied to the differences between cultures. (Garcia Calclini 2000: 47)

The charge is that a flattening of differences is secured at the very moment that celebrates difference and the creative productivity of new mixings. This flattening has infected the terms of scholarship to the core. In a provocative volume, *Ethics After Idealism* (1998), Rey Chow suggests that the popularized concepts of hybridity, diversity and pluralism may be grouped with others such as heteroglossia, dialogism, heterogeneity and multiplicity, as well as with notions of the post-colonial and cosmopolitan. Her point is that these con-

cepts all serve to 'obliterate' questions of politics and histories of inequality, thereby occluding 'the legacy of colonialism understood from the viewpoint of the colonized' and so able to 'ignore the experiences of poverty, dependency, subalterneity that persist well beyond the achievement of national independence' (Chow 1998: 155). Chow continues in a way that takes to task the metropolitan celebrant of the hybrid: 'The enormous seductiveness of the postmodern hybridite's discourse lies ... in its invitation to join the power of global capitalism by flattening out past injustices' in a way that accepts the extant relations of power and where 'the recitation of past injustices seems tedious and unnecessary' (Chow 1998: 156).

The same distraction might be discerned in enthusiasm for the figure of the cyborg in Haraway, and science fiction. This is not to say that this erasure of past injustice happens in the same way, but the cyborg as a kind of robot ignores the politics of race by displacing the not quite (not white) human into a future scenario rather than recall the registers of difference, racism and slavery. As was discussed in the previous chapter, Baudrillard linked the theme of slavery with that of revolt, and it is not innocent coincidence that these themes must be suppressed. The dangerous sexualized underbelly of hybridity must be contained and restrained just as the robots and servant-slaves of dominant humanoids must always obey. Here the comprador and collaborative force is strong in diaspora and hybridity, where elite transnationals have a vested interest in working on both sides of the transnational connection. Ramaswami Harindranath describes 'an economic, political and cultural elite "hybrid" class' who collaborate with global capital in a reconstituted cultural imperialism (Harindranath 2003: 160). The consequence, however, is that it becomes possible to forget colonial violence, white supremacy, systematic exploitation and oppression: for those who can join the 'belonging' reserved to the compliant elite fraction of hybridizing capital, hybridity saves.

As already noted, it is Spivak who is the most critical thinker here, pointing out that attention to migrancy and hybridity reserves importance to the metropolitan sphere and leaves the zones of exploitation, as arraigned across international divisions of labour, in darkness. In several books, but most explicitly in her *Critique of Postcolonial Reason*, she repeatedly takes to task those hybridized and diasporized members of the cosmopolitan set who market themselves as representatives of the culture they call origin from the luxurious comfort they now call home (Spivak 1999: 191, 361).¹² This is 'going native' in a rather different way: brown employees of the World Bank, IMF and UN conference circuit can only politely be called hybrid. In this conception, hybridity is about the opportunism of diasporic migrants seduced by complicity and advantage. Spivak's critique centres upon the mode of 'post-colonialism' which takes the place of 'the thoroughly stratified larger theatre of the South', by displacing interest and attention to that 'South' by way of a 'migrant hybridism' so that the South 'is once again in shadow, the diasporic stands in for the native informant' (Spivak 1999:

168–169). Subalterneity is occluded or flattened (despite the problems there might be with subaltern talk) by the celebrated access of hybridity talk. This is achieved with the help of the scholarly enthusiasm for hybridity, as discussed above: ‘An unexamined cultural studies internationally, joins hands with an unexamined ethnic studies ... to oil the wheels of what can only be called the ideological state apparatus ... triumphalist hybridism as well as nostalgic nativism. Business as usual’ (Spivak 1999: 319n).

The ‘business as usual’ that remains to be studied here is the culture industry's co-option of cultural difference. The sophisticated artistic or rustic-ified ethnic performance of culture sits comfortably with an upward mobility of middle-class aspiration in the globalized ecumene. Beneficiaries of surplus while their class underlings succumb, the cultural effervescence of hybridity is indulgent insofar as it no longer contests monoculture but rather facilitates a corporate multicultural.

Perhaps the final lesson should be wrought from the work of the scholar who has inspired so much of the interest in hybridity, which these last two chapters have outlined. Bhabha writes:

In my own work I have developed the concept of hybridity to describe the construction of cultural authority within conditions of political antagonism or inequity. Strategies of hybridization reveal an estranging movement in the ‘authoritative’, even authoritarian inscription of the cultural sign ... the hybrid strategy or discourse opens up a space of negotiation where power is unequal but its articulation may be equivocal. Such negotiation is neither assimilation nor collaboration. (Bhabha 1996: 58)

Is it unreasonable to think that the word hybridity – as a cover for so many things, an avoidance of much politics – is also a way of not saying dialectics? In Bhabha's discussion, the notion of dialectics is prominent.¹³ He writes that for Franz Fanon, those who ‘initiate the productive instability of revolutionary change are themselves the bearers of a hybrid identity’ and these people become the ‘very principle of dialectical reorganization, constructing their culture from the national text translated into modern Western forms of information technology, language, dress’ (Bhabha 1994: 38). Yet this process and ‘commitment to theory’ seems to be carefully disarticulated from that body of theory that would think dialectics as an internationalist revolutionary project. For Bhabha, ‘the problematic of political judgement’ cannot be represented as a ‘dialectical problem’ (Bhabha 1994: 24). He wants to take his ‘stand’ on the ‘shifting margins of cultural displacement’, and asks ‘what the function of a committed theoretical perspective might be’ if the point of departure is the ‘cultural and historical hybridity of the postcolonial world’ (Bhabha 1994: 21). He continues: ‘Hybrid agencies find their voice in a dialectic that does not seek cultural supremacy or sovereignty’ (Bhabha 1996: 58). Faced with ‘politics’, Bhabha rhetorically asks: ‘Committed to what? At this stage in the argument, I do not

want to identify any specific “object” of political allegiance’ (Bhabha 1994: 21). What he offers instead is an ‘inter-national *culture*’ based not on the ‘exoticism or multiculturalism of the diversity of cultures, but on the inscription and articulation of culture’s hybridity’ (Bhabha 1994: 38). This has been a recurrent problem for us throughout this book – notions of ‘partial culture’, ‘shifting sands’ and ‘versions of historic memory’ occlude another, and possibly more radical politics. The ambivalence analysed in the hybrid threatens to incapacitate the politics of ‘intervening ideologically’ (Bhabha 1994:22). When Trinh T. Minh-ha writes: ‘after a while, one becomes tired of hearing concepts such as in-betweenness, border, hybridity and so on. ... But we will have to go on using them so that we can continue what Mao called “the verbal struggle”’ (in Trinh and Morelli 1996:10), there might be reason to feel very hostile to notions of hybridity simply as translation. The struggle goes beyond mere word play: the effort requires us to see the term reclaimed from racist biology to do work for anti-essentialism, which itself reifies and must be countered in turn. Hybridity, then, becomes a new mode of essentializing, which is subsequently conceived as a verb – hybridization – but which further excludes and so must be questioned again. And none of this makes sense if it is not taken into organized politics, critical of going native, co-constituted here and there, and where we still think that interpretation and understanding is not yet enough. Openness to redistribution requires the mechanism of wanting to change the way things too often simply ‘are’. Thus, dialectically, we would still have this coda: there is ‘a world to win’.

Notes

1 This is also significant in the contexts of migration and asylum or refugee debates in the UK as well as in Australia. Under Minister Blunkett, the ‘Home Office’ became the arbiter of more than security; its passport bureaucracy calibrates identity in general.

2 The ascription of Hindu to a religious category belies this definition of the peoples of India. Persians used the label to describe people in geographic terms: those on the other side of the Indus river.

3 The solace provided by the realization that this situation can only further ready the population for uprising is tempered only by astonishment that they don’t.

4 Sharma and Housee (1999); Sharma et al. (1996); Alexander (2002); also see the informative special issue of *Amer-Asia Journal*, Vol. 25, No. 3, 2000 for a politicizing take on the cultures of South Asian youth in America (Prashad and Mathew 1999–2000: ix).

5 The all too rapid sprinkling of tracts which alibi identity politics and entrenched positions with an automated recourse to the strategy of being essentialist – as if this was all that the critical term ‘strategic essentialism’ implied – misses what was important in Spivak’s contextualizing use of the phrase. See the interview with her ‘Subaltern Talk’ in Spivak (1996).

6 Actually all of these could be called hybrid, and no doubt will be in time, and television obviously should be, as a cartoon in Marshall McLuhan’s book *The Medium is the Message* (1967) quips, the conjunction of the word tele-vision, made from Latin and Greek, can never be expected to produce anything worthwhile. He meant it in jest – and not that there ever was some ‘pure’ *telos* corrupted by a ‘pure’ vision (Heraclitus notwithstanding).

7 A more appropriate and idiomatically translated title for the Japanese release of the film was *Falling in Love with Beckham* (2003), thus exposing an underlying white supremacist Aryan fantasy in the displaced racial romantic celebrity desire of Tokyo teens.

8 Neither Marlow nor Kurtz offer models for going native. Perhaps another possible reclaimed anthropology does – its fieldwork and participant observation continually in tension, examined, evaluated; its collaborative and activist aspects foregrounded; solidarity as a watchword? Perhaps?

9 We must stress that we are not at all anti-theory, just not *only* for theory.

10 See <http://www.noborder.org/camps/02/aus/>.

11 Che-Leila is a non party-affiliated organization in Britain that will provide support to the international movements who are fighting imperialism, which is the source of poverty, hunger, destitution and humiliation in oppressed peoples’ countries (see http://www.worldalternative.org/palestine/che_leila.htm). The documentation project organized by Anandi Ramumurthy collects artefacts from various anti-racist and anti-imperialist campaigns by Asian Youth Movements at <http://www.tandana.org>.

12 In a discussion of cultural nativism and the New World Order, Spivak teaches a reading of Gramsci that is helpful here, and it is worth reproducing one of her footnotes in full. She writes:

Indeed, Gramsci is useful here if read freely. Necessarily without a detailed awareness of the rich history of African-American struggle, he was somewhat off the mark when he presented the following ‘hypothesis’ for verification: ‘1. that American expansionism should use American Negroes [*sic*] as its agents in the conquest of the African market and the extension of American civilization’ [from

Gramsci 1971: 21]. ... If, however, these words are applied to the new immigrant intellectuals and their countries of national origin, the words seem particularly apposite today. The partners are, of course, 'Cultural Studies', liberal multiculturalism, and post-fordist transnational capitalism. (Spivak 1993: xx).

13 It is clearly the case that the Marxist notion of dialectics relies more upon flux movement and flow than what the orthodox, Hegelian and tripartite presentation of thesis, antithesis and synthesis may imply.

- hybridity
- hybridization
- diaspora
- cultural hybridity
- syncretism
- essentialism
- culture industries

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